

What is Cognitive Bias?

A cognitive bias is a mental error that causes you to misinterpret information from the environment, affecting the logic and correctness of your decisions and judgments. Biases are unconscious, automatic processes that speed up and improve the efficiency of decision-making. Heuristics (mental shortcuts), societal pressures, and emotions, for example, can all contribute to cognitive biases.

Bias is a tendency to favour or oppose a person, group, concept, or item, usually in an unjust way. Biases are natural — they're a part of our makeup — and they don't only live in our heads; they have an impact on how we make decisions and act.

Biases are divided into two categories in psychology: conscious and unconscious biases. You are aware of your attitudes and the behaviours that emerge from them when you have conscious bias, also known as explicit bias. Explicit bias can be beneficial since it gives you a feeling of self and helps you make excellent judgments (for example, being biased towards healthy foods). However, when these biases manifest themselves as conscious stereotyping, they can be extremely hazardous.

Unconscious bias, also known as cognitive bias, refers to a set of unintentional biases in which you are unaware of your attitudes and the behaviours that emerge from them. We get around 11 million bits of information each second, but we can only analyse about 40 bits per second, thus cognitive bias is often the product of your brain's attempt to simplify information processing. As a result, we frequently rely on mental shortcuts (also known as heuristics) to help us make sense of the world quickly. As a result, these errors are frequently caused by issues with thinking, such as memory, attention, and other mental errors.

Unconscious biases, like conscious prejudices, can be useful because they don't involve much mental effort and allow you to make decisions fast. However, much like conscious biases, unconscious biases can also be destructive prejudice that harms an individual or a group.

A brief history of cognitive biases

Israeli psychologists Amos Tversky and Daniel Kahneman created the term “cognitive bias” in the 1970s to explain people's erroneous habits of thinking in response to judgement and decision issues. The heuristics and biases study programme of Tversky and Kahneman looked into how people make decisions with limited resources (for example, limited